THE NEXT 100

POLITICS

CAPTAIN TRINAMOOL

ABHISHEK BANERJEE, 34

Lok Sabha MP and National General Secretary, Trinamool Congress, West Bengal

"Abhishek has an architect's acumen in all that he does. He wants to focus on renewed investment in the state"

SUKHENDU SHEKHAR RAY

Rajya Sabha MP, TMC

He has none of the political flamboyance of his feisty aunt. Abhishek appears unflappable at all times, letting nothing get to him—not the *bua-bhatija* barbs, not allegations of dynastic rule, nor ED summoning him and wife Rujira to join in a coal smuggling probe.

Instead, he focuses on the task at hand, which, in 2021, was to take on the mighty BJP electoral machine, steered by the country's prime minister, home minister and other saffron heavyweights. Standing by Mamata Banerjee like a rock, he encouraged her to go full throttle against the BJP juggernaut, following a script he engaged Prashant Kishor for. Braving criticism and partymen's exodus, Abhishek implemented Kishor's recommendation to deny tickets to under-performing, unpopular, corrupt and disloyal sitting MLAs. For the first time in TMC history, a third of the sitting MLAs were dropped. However, even as he allowed the poll strategist a free hand, he unleashed a social media campaign, manned by professionals, to counter the BJP narrative. Vindication came in the form of TMC's giant-killing win.

Now he is the captain of Didi's expedition to extend TMC's footprint beyond Bengal. Gradually becoming his party's public face, he is introducing reform in the party organisation to make it cadre-based and disciplined. He has implemented a one-man, one-post policy to check the concentration of power in a few hands and a fair and transparent distribution of tickets and portfolios, based on performance and not clout or political weight. He's also grooming a crop of young leaders, giving them posts and responsibilities, to take the baton when the time comes. ■

–Romita Datta



GADGET FREAK Abhishek loves to splurge on the latest electronic gadget. Recently upgraded to an iPhone 13